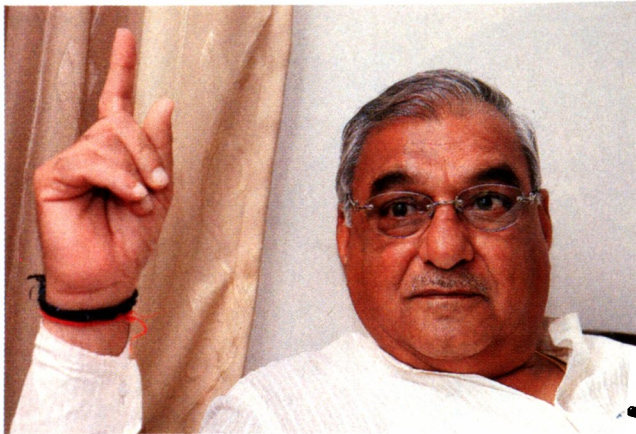


AMIT KUMAR



Playing a Sop Opera

CHANDIGARH Haryana Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda has perfected the art of keeping MLAs and MPs, cutting across party lines, in good humour. After lavishing a raise on the MLAs' perks, giving luxury cars to ministers and laptops to all the legislatures, he has now approved a policy for

allotment of plots and flats to all the 10 sitting MPs and 90 MLAs of the state at reserve price fixed by Haryana Urban Development Authority (HUDA). The plots being offered are in Gurgaon and Panchkula, the hot spots of real estate close to the national and the state capitals respectively.

HOUSE THAT: Hooda

Predictably, the Cabinet, presided over by Hooda, unanimously cleared the policy at its meeting on July 14. The only rider is that the MP or MLA should not already be a member of group housing societies which have been allotted land by the draw of lots by HUDA.

Knowing too well that most of the MPs and MLAs have already availed such housing, the new policy has been ingenious enough to provide them a solution to get around this catch—they can give up their memberships of the societies to become eligible under the new scheme. Clearly, Hooda has taken the real estate route straight to the hearts of the MPs and MLAs in his state.

by Ramesh Vinayak

Back to School

BANGALORE With more than half of the 110 BJP legislators in the current Assembly being first-timers, the party has hit upon an innovative way to "educate" them. Apart from the routine political tutoring from their political bosses, plans are on for a day-long refresher course in the

GIREESH G V



The Vidhan Soudha

art of politics at the Centre for Public Policy at the IIM-Bangalore where former Karnataka chief secretary A. Ravindra is adjunct faculty.

Ravindra, who is also in the BJP think-tank here, feels the short academic input will help these legislators improve their performance in the Assembly. Even Karnataka Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa, who had to face a tough time with noncooperative members in the first session, feels that the youngsters will benefit from this academic input.

Senior BJP legislator and Law Minister Suresh Kumar believes that this kind of input from top-of-the-line management could have been of great value even for old timers. Hopefully, the coming assembly sessions will see healthy, educated debates instead of the chaos that usually prevails in the House.

by Stephen David

Fear Capital

DELHI Fear stalks the city again. A spate of shootouts in busy thoroughfares and crowded markets in the last week has citizens of the capital living in panic. The night of July 11 marked the beginning of this series, when two armed men on a motorcycle shot three persons in two separate incidents in south Delhi. The next day, two businessmen were gunned down again in the South district. The evening of July 14 grieved the death of another in the Delhi suburb of Noida when a brawl between two businessmen turned ugly.

If it's not chain snatching, it's an attempted bank heist that triggers



SUDHANSHU MALHOTRA

GORY END: An everyday happening

the killing. The city's denizens agree that the police are not up to their jobs and the law and order situation is going from bad to worse. Delhi's 60,000-strong police force is larger than the law enforcement forces in mega cities like New York, London or Tokyo, all of which have a larger population than the

national capital.

However, Police Commissioner Y.S. Dadwal cites a staff crunch in defence of his force. He may have a point. A large number of officers are permanently on VIP duty, to ensure that the netas and their families are safe. It's the common man who pays with his life.

by Shveta Srivastava